

Mannerist painting

As well as the Protestant Reformation causing massive upheavals across Europe, the 16th century saw outbreaks of plague and the Ottoman Turks attack Vienna. Many of the harmonious ideals of the Renaissance were abandoned, and numerous artists imitated Michelangelo's mature, gestural style, exaggerating figures, colours and compositions.

In the 20th century, the style was retrospectively labelled Mannerism. Jacopo Pontormo (1494–1557) painted sculptural figures, thrusting them towards the edges of his compositions. His pupil Angelo di Cosimo, or Bronzino (1503–72), worked as court painter to the Medici. His elegant paintings seem detached, while El Greco painted in a unique, darkly dramatic elongated style. Parmigianino (1503–40), an Italian painter and printmaker, created elongated, graceful images with unusual perspectives and deliberated poses. The Venetian Jacopo Robusti, better known as Tintoretto (1518–94), experimented with dynamic perspectives and unusual lighting to create energetic and lyrical pictures.



Pontormo, *The Deposition from the Cross*, 1525–8